

Failed promises: A May 1, 2024 picture shows the Nassau County International Cricket Stadium under construction in Eisenhower Park in East Meadow, New York, ahead of the ICC T20 World Cup 2024. Six ICC-standard stadiums were supposed to have been ready in the country by 2024 (later extended by a year due to Covid-19), but only one (Grand Prairie, Texas) is complete. AFP



payments.

That dependency — rare in American sports — now sits at the heart of a governance crisis.

A billion-dollar deal under review

USA Cricket's June breach notice charged ACE with several failures. A close examination of the Term Sheet, ACE's July 8 rebuttal, and supporting legal documents reveals the following:

Alleged breaches

Stadium delivery failure: The contract required six ICC-standard stadiums by 2024 (later extended by a year due to Covid-19). Only one (Grand Prairie, Texas) is complete, and ACE has shifted the responsibility of building infrastructure to MLC franchises without USA Cricket's written consent. Section 24 of the Term Sheet states: "Except in the event of a transfer to an affiliate, the Agreement, including USA Cricket's exclusive license for Major and Minor Leagues, is transferable or assignable to another party only with

the written consent of USA Cricket."

The Morrisville, Lauderhill, and Oakland stadiums are not owned or exclusively operated by ACE, and it has pushed the completion timelines to 2028, well outside the agreed timeline in the Term Sheet. The Term Sheet states in Section 5.1 that ACE must "make commercially reasonable efforts to ensure that the stadiums will be operational by no later than 2024" and that it must control "all stadium events and activities".

Revenue share dilution: The term sheet entitles USA Cricket to 5 per cent of all gross cricket-related revenues. ACE's plan to devolve local sponsorships and media deals to franchises (starting 2027) risks shrinking that pool — and with it, USA Cricket's share.

Unapproved expansion: ACE's push for a Toronto-based franchise and a strategic tie-up with New Zealand Cricket was initiated without USA Cricket's sign-off. The March 2025 ICC sanctioning standards require that when an event is staged

in one federation's jurisdiction but played (in whole or part) in another's territory, both national bodies must sign off. USA Cricket says no such approval was sought for ACE's plans outside the U.S.

ACE's response to this is that the events have not occurred yet and that it will comply with ICC rules, if and when they do.

Player/staff salary shortfall: USA Cricket cited a \$606,189 (player and staff payment for a period of July 1, 2024 to December 31, 2024) and a \$647,603 (January 1, 2025 to June 23, 2025) payment lapse. ACE responded with records showing \$1.43 million paid in 2024 to players, coaches, and staff eligible for U.S. national teams.

ACE calculated the payment made based on the MLC Draft salary paid by franchisees to U.S. domestic players according to Term 3.3: "... The amounts, structure and format of the contracts for the players, coaches and support staff will be the sole discretion of ACE, or the JV, as applicable" and 3.4 which states: "All contracts for professional players for